

This video claims that AI is good for environment. What do you think?

Posted by u/Raudys • 0 points • 13 comments

I posted this on another sub, but mods didn't approve it. What do you guys here think?

Comments

u/Classic_Flower_735 • 1 points • 2025-11-26 02:58 UTC

"Air pollution /cigarette smoke/ pesticides/micro plastics etc etc all this stuff is GOOD for you! You should just get over it and learn to LIKE it all!"

u/Classic_Flower_735 • 1 points • 2025-11-26 02:55 UTC

ANY issue where there is a great deal of money to be made for a significant number of people and entities? OF COURSE DUHH evil human nature will ALWAYS kick in to LIE if there is harm involved that could reduce bottom line profits...anyone that just trusts the hired experts etc is a gullible FOOL! SO SO many examples with big tobacco and pesticides etc etc...humans will just LIE even to their own selves if it involves money

u/GoodMiddle8010 • 1 points • 2025-11-10 01:27 UTC

It may not be directly good for the environment but neither is any other modern technology and many commonly used technologies are much worse than AI

u/Even_Media_4686 • 1 points • 2025-11-09 10:22 UTC

It actually is - if you think about how much real estate and how many resources it takes to produce, say, a hollywood movie. with explosions, exotic believable locations, etc.

Artists also have to be paid when it comes to collaborative projects. And they have to be fed while they are making art. And while they are making art - somebody else has to grow their food, do their plumbing, etc.

So at the end of the day it's literally cheaper to create AI art. Though it depends on what you're trying to achieve...

People will still make hand-crafted art. And it will be even more valuable thanks to AI Art, not less. So everyone wins.

u/Salt-Standard9587 • 1 points • 2025-11-09 14:07 UTC

What's your point with artists ? AI or no they still need money and food, being human beings and all

But yeah, it is indeed cheaper to not pay people, I will give you that

u/Even_Media_4686 • 1 points • 2025-11-09 14:18 UTC

That's not what's in the post.

u/Tyler_Zoro • 1 points • 2025-11-09 06:22 UTC

I don't think they have a leg to stand on, any more than the people who say that AI is a huge burden on the environment. Sure, the extremes of both views seem unlikely, but the reality is that we don't have sufficient data. This is why people keep conflating data center metrics with AI or estimating absurdly high-end resources for every query. No one actually publishes the numbers, so everyone is guessing.

u/Euchale • 1 points • 2025-11-08 22:29 UTC

I'm a lines on maps kinda guy. "Don't look at what people say, look at what people do."

AI companies are not building nuclear power plants for fun. They build it because they expect that they need the electricity.

u/After-Result4938 • 1 points • 2025-11-09 08:11 UTC

i dont get whats wrong with building nuclear power plants

u/jay-ff • 1 points • 2025-11-08 16:10 UTC

Okay I will give some criticism because while most people complaining about AIs environmental impact don't really go into depth, he doesn't either and just counters hand waving with more hand waving and numbers that don't tell you a lot.

1. The per-prompt estimation of energy is neat if you want to gain an intuition about what it takes to run these models but it's almost meaningless to judge the environmental impact because we don't have information on how many prompts are being processed. Most calls to AI models are probably not casual google-search replacements and estimating an AI-related footprint based on how many prompts you type into chatGPT will be completely missing the total power consumption. Everybody does this in this argument and it drives me crazy. There are people running agents on separate machines that just abuse unlimited query plans for hundreds of dollars by vibe coding 24/7 at max speed that probably consume more GPU time than thousands of people creating GPT travel itineraries. We don't directly see in our daily lives what products and content we consume has how many hours of GPU time in the background. You have to look at data in total power consumption and judge from there. He does that partially later in the video but comes back to talk about CO2 per prompt and says using AI would be good for the environment because we do less other activities instead. This again ignores that ordinary people prompting aren't really driving most of the prompting anyway (and is also not serious. I will not prompt AI instead of eating or driving a car).

2. I think his argument about focussing on AI instead of focussing on more meaningful ways of reducing carbon emissions is somewhat valid. I wouldn't tell someone to minimise prompts to chatGPT to save a few wh here and there for the reason I wrote in 1. That means being overly doomerish about AI energy consumption (or water consumption) takes it a few steps too far, at least when the message is to keep personal AI usage in check. If AI is useful to you, it's probably worth the direct energy footprint. Remember: Most of the energy is probably spent somewhere else anyway in the same way that it doesn't make sense to worry too much about raising your shower temperature by a few degrees. And in general, if you look at the global AI power consumption and think it's worth the output we get from it, this is a fair conclusion. I still think we should take it seriously as a problem but I would rank it lower than other issues.

3. However: His argument that AI is good for the environment is garbage and I don't even really understand it. One reason is his first argument that using AI for things means you're not doing something else with your time. This is an unserious point because it just makes a bunch of oversimplified assumptions such as that activities like AI are substitutes for things we use energy for. If that argument was made with regards to google searches or maybe entertainment, there could be a point there but in general, people don't shower less to do more AI art and their workplace isn't suddenly 20 minutes closer to home so you can drive less and do more prompting. The vast majority of energy consumption for a western household is mobility, heating and process heat. Both have no relationship to how much you prompt (I will accept the argument that using your own GPU for AI on a cold day is energy neutral though :)). He also brings up how much more energy commissioning artists costs without ignoring the fact that we didn't have ordinary people commissioning 20 artists a day to generate pictures. Comparing ai art to art commissioning is as unserious as the time argument. Do your research but I will bet a high amount of money that the entire industry of creating still images(include whatever profession you like) still consumes less energy than all of AI today. Scaling matters.

The other argument seems to be something like that AI stimulates adaptations that lead to a better environment such as commissioning nuclear power plants. This is unconvincing to me because data centers don't specifically require nuclear energy so they incentivise the commissioning of any uninterrupted energy source, be it a nuclear power plant, coal/gas power plants or even gas turbines when new big plants aren't coming online quickly enough. He also dismisses the argument that AI is on average more dirty than the average kWh by pointing to stuff like electric cars. I think it's important though that AI is dirtier because of idiosyncratic reasons, specifically enormous power requirements and 24/7 operation. This is much harder to greenify than electric cars for example because you have some flexibility in how you charge your car and when. I know several people that charge their cars with solar panels. He makes a similar argument at other places where he sais that stuff like water contamination because of data center construction doesn't count to the negative effects because it is construction and not operation of AI.

So in summary: he makes some valid points, especially about water, but his main thesis, that AI is good for the environment is not really supported by what he sais.

u/4tomicZ • 1 points • 2025-11-08 17:59 UTC

Thank you for this! I think it's a good write up.

It feels like there is equal potential for AI to save energy or waste it. It really comes down to how we use it.

I think what we're outputting also matters. If we're just getting more efficient at producing garbage marketing to sell garbage products, then I think it's all a waste.

u/Peach-555 • 7 points • 2025-11-08 15:02 UTC

[https://preview.redd.it/7xavsufbs10g1.png?](https://preview.redd.it/7xavsufbs10g1.png?width=706&format=png&auto=webp&s=faf0b448331b6c0cf945064465bd9c5e7818be54)

[width=706&format=png&auto=webp&s=faf0b448331b6c0cf945064465bd9c5e7818be54](https://preview.redd.it/7xavsufbs10g1.png?width=706&format=png&auto=webp&s=faf0b448331b6c0cf945064465bd9c5e7818be54)

If a prompt cost \$0.000004, then it can't possibly use more than \$0.000004 in electricity. A subscription could not cost \$20 per month, if it use more than \$20 per month in electricity on average. AI accounts for less than 1% of water/electricity use currently, if it keeps growing fast, it might account for a couple percents in some years, and if things go wild, maybe 20% of the electricity use, but it is possible to increase the electricity generation.

u/vlladonxxx • 1 points • 2025-11-09 00:18 UTC

>A subscription could not cost \$20 per month, if it use more than \$20 per month in electricity on average

Well, no, it can. Chat GPT famously loses money on its service, still holding off on properly monetizing it. Much like Uber was losing money for years before they became a money printing machine they are now. Just saying.

u/Peach-555 • 4 points • 2025-11-09 06:42 UTC

A distinction has to be made between ChatGPT subscriptions and the tokens being sold and OpenAI the company.

OpenAI spends more money than it earns, by expanding infrastructure, buying data, training new models, wages. ChatGPT still makes money on the average subscriber and API tokens being sold.

But even if they lost money on average per subscriber, the cost of running the models is mostly the hardware, not the electricity. A \$25,000 H100 use less than \$0.1 in electricity per hour.

u/NarrowPhrase5999 • 3 points • 2025-11-08 14:37 UTC

We all know its hyped up to support a headline and that its likely just the same as Google, Reddit, Facebook's water usage, but take both sides where they use extremities to cement their point against the other side and any nuance stops mattering 🤔